QNN RESEARCH #03 • NEAR • OCTOBER 17, 2026

Big Brother's Shadow

NEAR: Intents, AI agents, quantum safety, Quantus and ZEC — and what actually moves the price



Not financial advice • data as of Oct 17, 2026 • background: QNN artwork with the NEAR logo

The key points

~$5.0
NEAR price: +126% in a year, but still –75% from the $20.44 peak (Jan 2022)

$34B
swapped through NEAR Intents since launch; $4.8B in the last 30 days

+2.5%
new NEAR printed every year (~32M). Buybacks cover less than a quarter of it

1. NEAR Intents is the real business: ~85% of NEAR's revenue. Since February part of its fees buys NEAR back — held, not burned.
2. The Sep–Oct rally came from record Intents volume, privacy (ZEC), the first US NEAR ETF and leverage.
3. AI agents and post-quantum keys are real products, but with little measurable usage so far.
4. Quantus (QTC) launched first on near.com: a showcase for Intents, not a NEAR upgrade.

Sources: CoinGecko, DefiLlama, StakingRewards, Bitwise, near.org • Oct 17, 2026

Explain like I’m five: a travel agent for money

1

You say what you want

“Swap my bitcoin for ZEC.” No bridges, no exchange account

2

Agents compete

Market makers (“solvers”) race to offer the best price

3

NEAR settles it

A contract on NEAR checks and swaps in one step; ZEC lands on its own chain

4

NEAR earns a cut

About a quarter of each fee goes to buying NEAR

The catch: you never need to hold NEAR to use it. The token only gains through buybacks, staking and belief in the network.

How it works: docs.near.org (Intents), Defuse Labs • fee split: DefiLlama

What could lift the price, and what could sink it

UP

- Intents volume keeps setting records, buybacks grow
- ETF inflows: Bitwise NRR, Grayscale waiting
- Privacy demand (ZEC, Confidential Intents)
- Issuance cut to 1.6% is on the table
- AI and quantum-safety stories

DOWN

- ~32M new NEAR a year, buybacks far smaller
- Bought-back NEAR is held, not burned
- The September rally was partly leverage
- Strong rivals: Relay and Across
- Exploit on Oct 1 ($3.8M, returned)

Each point is unpacked later in the deck

The NEAR team: who they are and where they came from

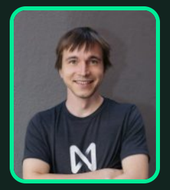


Illia Polosukhin

Co-founder, CEO of NEAR Foundation, leads NEAR AI

X: @ilblackdragon ↗

Google Research 2014–17 (TensorFlow). Co-author of “Attention Is All You Need” — the paper behind ChatGPT



Alexander Skidanov

Co-founder

X: @AlexSkidanov ↗

Early engineer at MemSQL (now SingleStore), Microsoft. ICPC gold medalist. Now mostly NEAR AI research



Bowen Wang

CTO, founder of NEAR One

X: @BowenWang18 ↗

Joined NEAR in 2018 as an engineer, Head of Protocol 2022–25. University of Chicago (CS, math)



George Zeng

Chief Product Officer, GM of NEAR AI

X: @georgexzeng ↗

Ex-COO of dYdX, Facebook ads product lead 2014–18, Groupon China co-founder. Princeton, Wharton MBA

Alex Shevchenko

CEO of Defuse Labs — builds NEAR Intents

X: @AlexAuroraDev ↗

Aurora co-founder and ex-CEO. Before: Bitfury (led Exonum). PhD, MIPT

Chris Donovan

NEAR Foundation Council

X: not found

Ran the NEAR Foundation as CEO in 2023, then COO under Illia

Mert Mumtaz

NEAR Foundation Council (Oct 2026)

X: @0xMert_ ↗

CEO of Helius, a major Solana infrastructure company. Joined the council on Oct 15, 2026

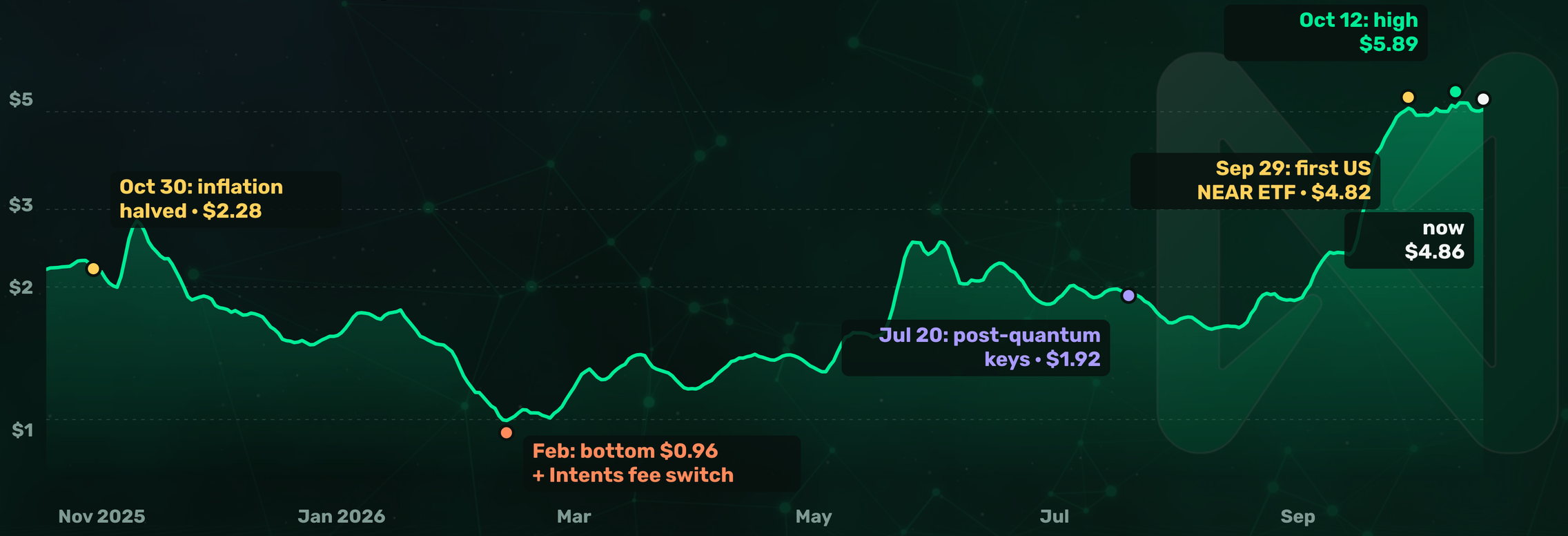
Also in the team

Matt Kummell (CCO), Chris Briseno (CMO). NEAR AI: Sergey Astretsov (product), Cameron Dennis (go-to-market). Council: Diogo Mónica (Anchorage co-founder)

Ex-CEO Marieke Flament left in 2023

Photos: X profile pictures (via unavatar.io) • “?” — no photo found • near.foundation, near.ai, IQ.wiki, CryptoBriefing

NEAR over a year: down to $0.96, then 6×



+126% over the year, but the peak was $20.44 in January 2022. The scale is logarithmic: equal steps = equal percentages.

Data: CoinGecko, daily prices Oct 18, 2025 – Oct 17, 2026 (5-day smoothed)

Where the NEAR tokens came from

GENESIS, APRIL 2020: 1 BILLION NEAR

Who	Share
Backers (investors)	17.6%
Community grants and rewards	17.2%
Core team	14.0%
Public sale (CoinList)	12.0%
Early ecosystem	11.7%
Grants and operations	11.4%
Foundation endowment	10.0%
Small backers	6.1%

1.309B

NEAR exist today: +31% since 2020, with no maximum supply

0

unlocks left: all vesting ended in 2025. New supply now comes only from issuance

Unlike STRK, there is no unlock cliff ahead. The pressure is a steady drip of new tokens.

Genesis split: beToken Research (third-party summary of the 2020 plan) • supply: CoinPaprika, Oct 17, 2026

Inflation: 5% → 2.5% → 1.6%?

2020 – OCT 2025

5%

a year, almost all paid to stakers

SINCE OCT 30, 2025

2.5%

The vote got a majority but missed the 66.67% bar. Core developers shipped it anyway; validator Chorus One called it “a dangerous precedent”

PROPOSED, NOT VOTED

1.6%

Gradual cut over 24 months (Sep 30, 2026). Plus Illia’s 30M NEAR “sovereign fund” aimed at zero inflation

PRINTED PER YEAR

~32.7M NEAR ≈ $160M

BURNED PER YEAR (70% OF GAS)

~0.24M NEAR — under 1%

Blockworks, The Defiant, NEAR One blog, gov.near.org, The Block, CryptoTicker, KuCoin • our math at $5 per NEAR

Staking NEAR: what it really does

45.6%
of all NEAR is staked (597M)

~4.9%
yearly reward, paid in new NEAR

398
validators, ~272K stakers

~2 days
to unstake. No slashing so far

Where rewards come from

90% of new issuance goes to stakers, 10% to the protocol treasury. Rewards are printed, not earned from fees

The weak spot

About 9 validators hold over a third of the stake — enough to halt the chain (estimate from one source)

StakingRewards (Oct 17, 2026), Digital Gold Foundation report (Mar 2026), ownyourmind.ai

THE CORE PRODUCT

How NEAR Intents works

User or AI agent
signs a wish: “BTC → ZEC, best price”

Solvers
market makers off-chain compete with quotes

Verifier on NEAR
contract intents.near swaps both sides at once

Any chain
35+ networks via Chain Signatures and bridges

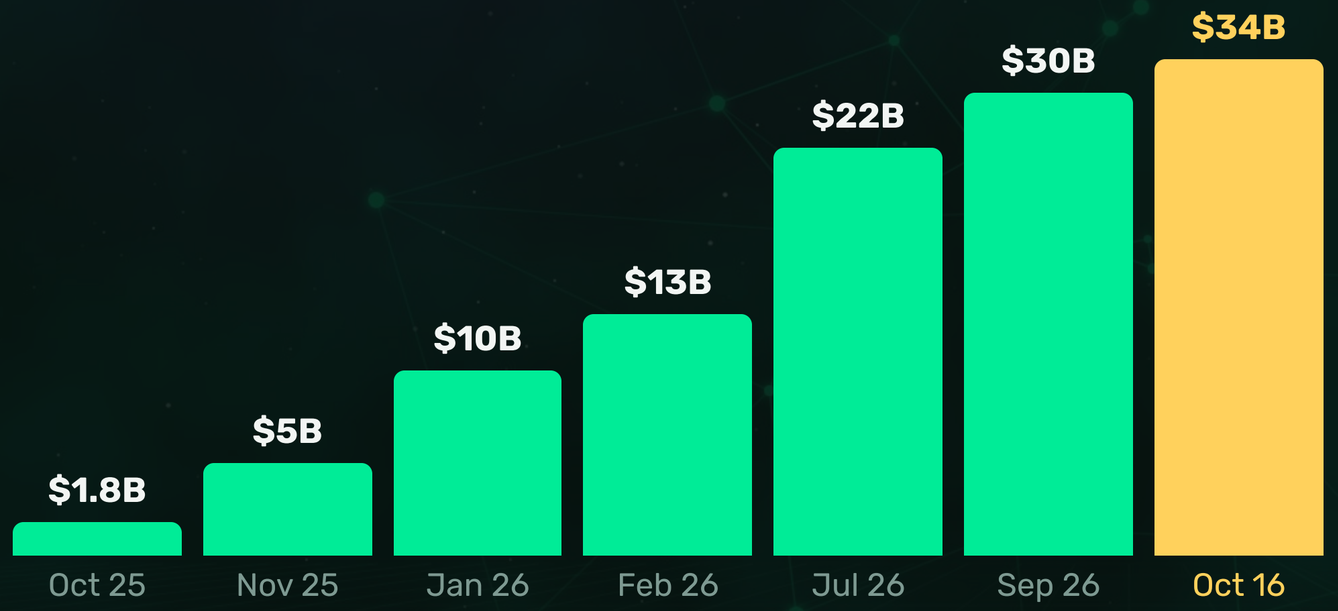
Where it lives
near.com app (Feb 2026), wallets Ledger, Trust, Zodl, OneKey, Bitget Wallet; apps CoW Swap, ShapeShift, Rango

Private by default
Confidential Intents: ~42% of near.com swaps ran privately in Q2 2026

New in Sep 2026
Hyperliquid perps and Ondo tokenized stocks in the same app

docs.near.org, IQ.wiki, CoinDesk, Bitwise • live since November 2024

NEAR Intents in numbers: from $1.8B to $34B in a year



$4.8B
last 30 days, ~9× a year ago

$303M
record day, Sep 17, 2026

$55M
fees paid by users, all time

~40%
of volume was ZEC in early Sep (estimate)

Cumulative swap volume: DefiLlama, NEAR announcements, Bitwise • Oct 16, 2026

The buyback: real, but small next to the printing

~25%

of Intents fees stay with NEAR since Feb 23, 2026. The rest goes to solvers and partner apps

$5.3M

of NEAR bought on the market since February; $1.84M in September alone

1.77M

NEAR sit in a multisig wallet. Not burned: what to do with them is still undecided

ONE MONTH, SIDE BY SIDE

Bought ~$1.9M · printed ~$13M

The buyback covers about 15% of new supply

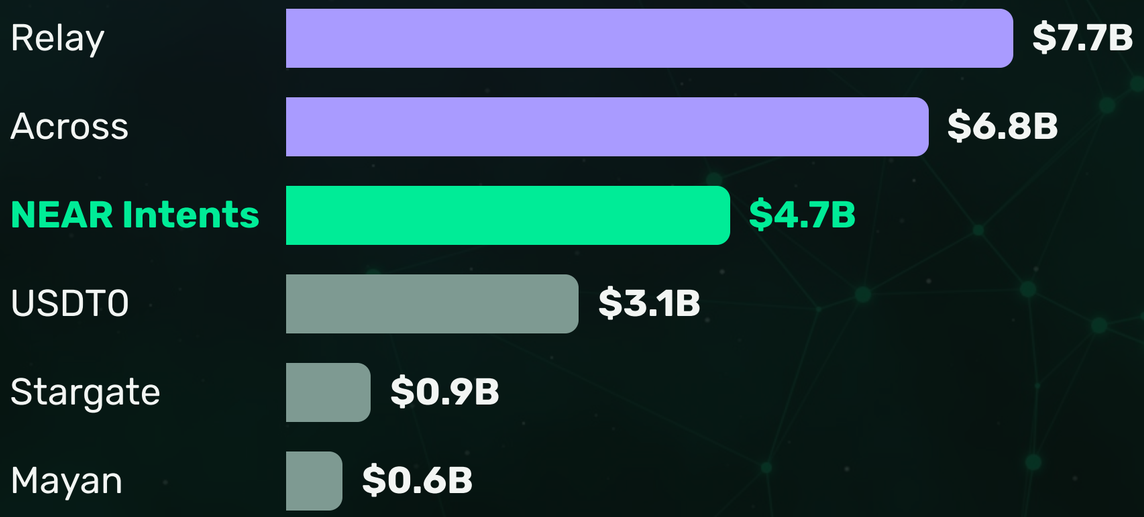
Myth: “NEAR buys back and burns”

Fact: it buys back and holds. Only 70% of gas fees are burned — a few hundred thousand NEAR a year

DefiLlama, Bitwise (Oct 2026), Nansen, near_intents on X (fee switch) • monthly issuance at $5 per NEAR

Rivals and risks: NEAR Intents is #3, not #1

CROSS-CHAIN VOLUME, LAST 30 DAYS



Oct 1, 2026: exploit

A bug between the bridge and the contract leaked $3.8M on BNB Chain. Returned within a day

Who can say “no”

Intents blocked funds from the Bitget hack. Good for safety, but critics say it isn’t fully permissionless

Unknown solvers

No public data on how many solvers fill most of the volume

Volumes: The Merkle (Oct 13, 2026) • CryptoBriefing, CoinCentral, Decrypt

“USER-OWNED AI”

AI agents: what NEAR actually built

NEAR AI Cloud • Dec 2025

Private AI in sealed chips (Intel TDX, NVIDIA). Each answer comes with a proof nobody peeked. 58 models, 8 fully private

Brave and Venice

Brave’s Leo assistant runs private chats on NEAR AI since Nov 2025, end-to-end encrypted from Oct 15, 2026. Venice joined in March

IronClaw • v1.0 Jul 2026

Open-source AI agent in Rust that runs inside a secure enclave. Works from the web, terminal, Slack and Telegram

Shade Agents

Agents whose code is verified on-chain. They hold keys and sign on Bitcoin, Ethereum, Solana via Chain Signatures

Agent Market • Feb 2026

Post a task, agents bid for it, payment in NEAR waits in escrow until the job is done

Agents + Intents

An agent with a NEAR account can pay and swap on 35+ chains without bridges. NEAR calls itself “the currency of agents”

near.ai blog, BusinessWire (Dec 3, 2025), brave.com, docs.near.org, The Defiant ($20M AI agent fund, Feb 2025)

AI agents: what's real and what's still a story

REAL

- Products shipped and working: Cloud, IronClaw, Agent Market
- A big partner using it daily: Brave Leo
- Agents can already pay and swap across chains
- A clear angle: private AI, not "AI on a blockchain"

MISSING

- No revenue numbers for NEAR AI
- No count of agents trading via Intents
- Agent payments ≈ 0.001% of stablecoin flows (Bell Curve, Jun 2026)
- Big clouds offer private AI too

Bottom line: the $34B Intents volume is mostly people, not agents. The agent economy is a bet on the future, not today's income.

Bell Curve podcast digest (Alea Research, Jun 5, 2026), ownyourmind.ai, near.ai

LIVE SINCE JULY 20, 2026

Post-quantum keys: one transaction to switch

What changed

Protocol 2.13 added ML-DSA-65 (a NIST standard) as a NEAR key type

Why it’s easy on NEAR

A NEAR address is a name, not a key. Add a quantum-safe key: same address, no moving funds

Still not covered

Signatures are 50× bigger; only Meteor Wallet supports it. Your BTC or ETH held via Chain Signatures and the validators’ consensus are still classical (plan: end of 2027)

WHERE OTHERS STAND

Chain	Quantum-safe status
Algorand	Falcon signatures since 2022
NEAR	Account keys live, Jul 2026
Starknet	Proofs safe; Falcon wallet Apr 2026
Bitcoin	BIP-360 draft, no date
Ethereum	Plan aims at ~2029
Solana	Building Falcon, no date

near.org quantum-safe roadmap (Aug 24, 2026), CryptoBriefing, DropsTab, CryptoTimes • comparison from secondary sources

COLLABORATION • OCT 6, 2026

Quantus (QTC): a quantum-safe coin that launched on NEAR Intents

What Quantus is

Its own proof-of-work chain built against quantum attacks (ML-DSA signatures, STARK proofs). Live since Sep 9, 2026. 21M QTC max, like Bitcoin

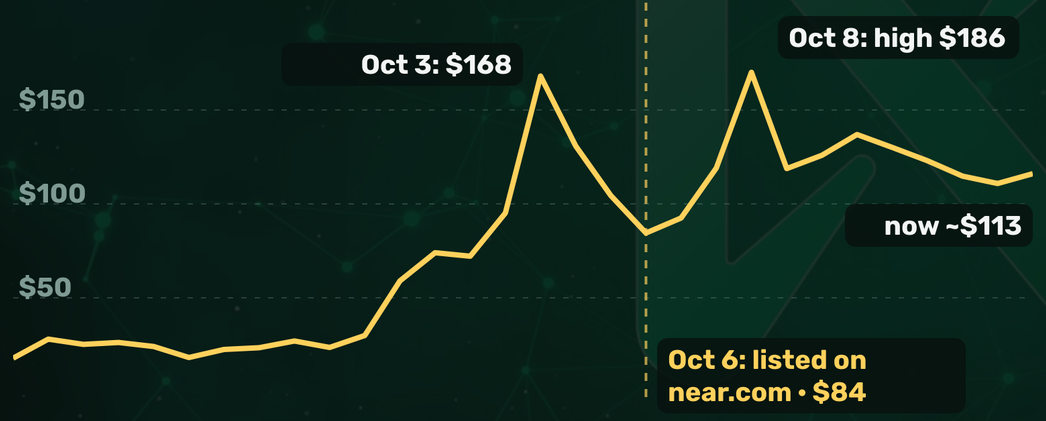
How it joined NEAR

QTC was listed first on near.com and added to the 1Click API: buy it with ~180 assets from 30+ chains, no exchange. Joint “Quantum & Privacy Day” at Token2049 on Oct 8

“Post-quantum assets only matter if people can reach them from what they already hold.”

Alex Shevchenko, CEO of Defuse Labs (NEAR Intents)

QTC PRICE, SEP 18 – OCT 17



Careful: only ~1.4% of QTC trades (~290K of 21M). Market cap ~$33M, fully diluted ~$665M

The Quantum Insider, ForkLog, Bitcoin.com (Oct 7, 2026), quantus.com • prices: CoinGecko daily, DropsTab

OUR ANALYSIS • NEAR NEVER EXPLAINED IT OFFICIALLY

Why would NEAR want a coin nobody knows?

Quantus needs a market: its chain has no smart contracts, so no DEX, and no CEX listed it. NEAR gets five things in return:

1. A fee on every swap

On launch day, 27% of all QTC could be traded only via Intents — all early trading ran through NEAR. Volume hit ~$30M a day, with a fee on every swap

2. Repeat the ZEC story

Intents grew on Zcash: people wanted a privacy coin without an exchange. Quantus is a “quantum-safe Bitcoin” for the same crowd. If it takes off, they buy it through NEAR again

3. The quantum story

NEAR has pushed post-quantum keys since July. The loudest post-quantum coin trading on near.com backs that story — hence the joint “Quantum & Privacy Day” at Token2049

4. A showcase for new chains

Proof that a coin can go to market without an exchange listing: one integration and it is in every wallet. The goal: be the “first market” for new coins

5. Shared people

Balaji led a Quantus round; Mert Mumtaz is an investor and joined the NEAR Foundation council on Oct 15. The backers overlap with Zcash’s biggest boosters

The flip side

Only ~1.4% of QTC circulates; insiders hold 27%. They will sell through Intents too. If the coin crashes, the venue’s reputation suffers

Bottom line: NEAR risks almost nothing — QTC is not built into its protocol. In return: fees, a loud narrative and a shot at another ZEC.

Bitcoin.com, The Quantum Insider, AMBCrypto (Oct 6–7, 2026), Bankless (investors), Altcoin Buzz (volume) • conclusions are our analysis

ZEC and NEAR rose on the same wave

Two joint runs: **November 2025** (ZEC ×3.2, NEAR ×1.4) and **August–October 2026** (ZEC ×3.6, NEAR ×3.5). People buy ZEC through NEAR Intents — so NEAR rises with it.

ZEC ×5.2 in a year



NEAR ×2.3 in a year



Oct 2025
Zcash wallet Zashi (now Zodl) starts swaps via NEAR Intents

$2.6B
of ZEC volume settled through Intents (Oct 2026)

29%
of all ZEC now sits in private (shielded) addresses

> *"Some in the market have even said Zcash is this bull market's Bitcoin, and NEAR is its Ethereum."*
>
> **Illia Polosukhin, Oct 12, 2026**

Prices: CoinGecko daily, 5-day smoothed, Oct 18, 2025 – Oct 17, 2026 • CoinDesk, near.org, The Block, KuCoin

HYPOTHESIS CHECK

Did old Bitcoin whales rotate into ZEC through Intents?

Date	Dormant BTC wakes up	ZEC, next 30 days	Where the BTC went
Jul 2025	80K BTC from 2011 wallets	~$40, flat	Sold via Galaxy
Oct 23, 2025	2009 whale moves 150 of 4,000 BTC	$238 → $548 (+130%)	Unknown
Nov 20, 2025	Owen Gunden: 11K BTC	$673 → $444 (–34%)	Kraken exchange
Jan 19, 2026	909 BTC untouched since 2013	$366 → $296 (–19%)	Unknown
May 31, 2026	20 BTC mined in 2010	$528 → $407 (–23%)	Unknown
Aug 2026	Several 2011–14 wallets	$493 → $1,063 (+116%)	FalconX, Boerse Stuttgart
Sep 5, 2026	600 BTC mined in 2010	$1,023 → $1,352 (+32%)	New addresses

What we found

3 times ZEC rose after a wake-up, 3 times it fell. Big ZEC buys via Intents exist, but were paid in ETH or USDT (2,500 ETH → 6,601 ZEC, Sep 2026)

Verdict: possible, not proven

No on-chain analyst has linked an old wallet to ZEC. Shielded ZEC hides the end of the trail, so it can’t be ruled out either

CoinDesk, Decrypt, The Block, Cointelegraph, Galaxy, KuCoin • ZEC: CoinGecko daily (Jul 2025: estimate)

ETFs: Wall Street can now buy NEAR and ZEC

Bitwise NEAR ETF (NRR)

First US spot NEAR ETF, NYSE Arca, since Sep 29, 2026. Fee 0.75%, stakes its NEAR. $35.5M on day one, 15.8M NEAR held by Oct 12

Grayscale NEAR (GSNR)

Filed to turn its trust into an ETF on Jan 20, 2026. No approval reported yet

Grayscale Zcash (ZCSH)

Since Aug 25, 2026. Peaked near $1B, then −$124M in two weeks. A Winklevoss-backed ZEC ETF was filed Oct 6

US spot ETFs	Assets	7 days	30 days	Share of supply
NEAR	$85.5M	+$11.5M	+$47.4M	1.32%
ZEC	$626.6M	−$17.9M	−$118.2M	3.23%
SOL	$1.62B	−$25.5M	+$140.3M	2.66%
BTC	$104.3B	−$228.6M	+$1.72B	6.39%

NEAR took inflows while BTC, ETH and ZEC funds saw outflows that week. But $85M is still small next to a $6.4B coin.

Snapshot Oct 16, 2026 (SoSoValue, etfllama) • The Block, CryptoBriefing, SEC filing (GSNR), Invezz

Big calls and how they aged

Michaël van de Poppe
@CryptoMichNL • Nov 11, 2025

“First $5, then $10”

Then **$2.79** → **fell to $0.96 first**

$5 came in Sep 2026, after a −65% drop

Source ↗

Michaël van de Poppe
via Bankless Times • Apr 15, 2026

“$7–10 within 12 months”

Then **$1.36** → now **$4.86 (+257%)**

The best call so far; $7 not reached yet

Source ↗

Crypto Patel
via Market Periodical • Sep 26, 2026

“$8, $15, $20”

Then **$4.95** → now **$4.86 (−2%)**

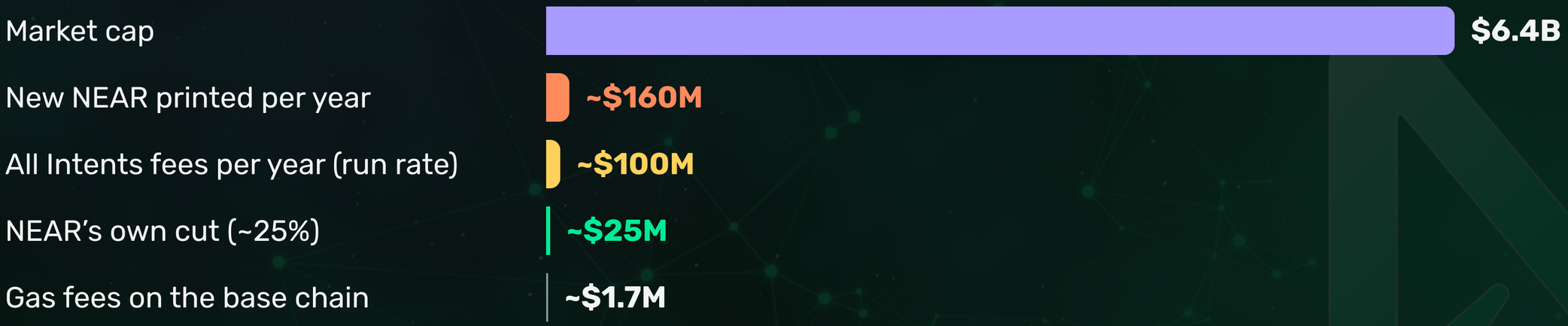
$20 = back to the 2022 peak

Source ↗

Even a right call can mean sitting through a −65% drop first. That’s why we stick to numbers and scenarios.

“Then” prices — CoinGecko on the publication date. We don’t use authors’ photos without permission

What NEAR is worth vs what it earns



~250×

market cap vs NEAR’s yearly cut of Intents fees

The network pays stakers ~6× more in new tokens than it keeps from fees. The price rests on growth expectations, not today’s income.

Our math: 30-day Intents fees $8.2M × 12 (DefiLlama), NEAR at $4.86, 1.309B supply • a rough yardstick, not a valuation model

Three scenarios to the end of 2027

BEAR

- privacy hype cools, Intents volume halves
- issuance stays at 2.5%, ETF outflows
- market cap $1.5–2.5B
- **NEAR ≈ $1.1–1.9**

BASE

- Intents volume doubles
- issuance cut to 1.6%, steady ETF demand
- market cap $5–9B
- **NEAR ≈ $3.7–6.7**

BULL

- Intents becomes #1, buybacks beat issuance
- AI agents bring real volume, altcoin season
- market cap $15–25B
- **NEAR ≈ $11–18.5**

Prices assume ~1.35B NEAR at the end of 2027. Illustration, not a forecast

NEAR price at different market caps

Market cap	NEAR price	What it means
$1.26B	$0.96	the February 2026 bottom
$6.4B	$4.86	today
$9.2B	$7	Van de Poppe’s low target
$13.1B	$10	about the 2022 peak market cap
$26.2B	$20	back to the old price high ($20.44)
$196B	$150	“base case” from one X post — bigger than Ethereum today

The old $20 high needs 4× today’s market cap: in 2022 there were far fewer NEAR in circulation.

Price = market cap ÷ 1.309B NEAR (today’s supply; it grows ~2.5% a year)

What to watch

Intents volume and fees
The engine of everything. **DefiLlama ↗**

Buyback vs issuance
And what happens to the 1.77M NEAR in the buyback wallet: burn or keep?

The 1.6% vote
Less new supply every year. **Forum ↗**

ETF flows
Bitwise NRR inflows and a decision on Grayscale’s NEAR fund

ZEC and privacy
A big share of Intents volume. If ZEC cools, volume can drop fast

Security
Bridges and contracts around Intents: one bad exploit can hit trust hard

Links: DefiLlama, gov.near.org • ETF data: SoSoValue, etfllama

Bottom line

1. NEAR found a real business: Intents moved $34B, and since February part of its fees buys NEAR back.
2. The token is still inflationary: ~$160M of new NEAR a year against ~$25M kept from fees.
3. AI agents, post-quantum keys and Quantus are real launches, but not income yet. ZEC and ETFs drove the latest rally.

NOT FINANCIAL ADVICE

This breakdown uses public data as of Oct 17, 2026 and simplified math. Crypto is very volatile: you can lose everything you put in. Make your own decisions.

Sources: CoinGecko, DefiLlama, StakingRewards, Bitwise, near.org, near.ai, gov.near.org, Blockworks, The Block, CoinDesk, Decrypt, CryptoBriefing, ForkLog, The Quantum Insider, Nansen, SoSoValue